The building blocks of English

GRAMMAR / LINGUISTICS / PHONETICS / SEMANTICS / SYNTAX / PRAGMATICS

A detailed companion to English Orbit

48 topic units. Original explanations, worked contrasts, pronunciation guidance, 96 practice questions and explained answers. A reference from first sentence patterns to advanced analysis.

Understand why language works

Move from forms to systems: how words are built, how speech is organised, how clauses fit together, how meanings combine and how context changes an utterance. Use this book alongside the six-level course or as a reference when a particular distinction is unclear.

For learners and teachers

Basic units support Starter and Elementary study. More technical units support upper-level learners and teachers who want to analyse English precisely. Difficulty labels are study guidance, not a proficiency certification.

Pronunciation model

IPA examples mainly use broad southern British dictionary conventions, with selected General American comparisons. Accent differences are explained where relevant. The goal is intelligibility, not removal of a learner’s identity.

The teaching prose, worked examples and exercises are original. Further-reading links at the end identify reference resources used to check notation and terminology. No third-party IPA chart is reproduced.

Open the English Orbit companion course

Find a topic / 1 of 2

Each title below links to its topic. The PDF also includes section bookmarks.

Linguistics

01 / Language as a system · 5

02 / Description, variation and register · 6

03 / Evidence, units and analytical tests · 7

04 / Morphemes and word formation · 8

Grammar

05 / Word classes and grammatical functions · 9

06 / Nouns, number and countability · 10

07 / Articles, reference and determination · 11

08 / Pronouns, case and reference · 12

09 / Adjectives, adverbs and comparison · 13

10 / Verb forms, finiteness and auxiliaries · 14

11 / Tense, time and aspect · 15

12 / Present simple and progressive · 16

13 / Past narration and the perfect · 17

14 / Future reference and modality · 18

15 / Negation, questions and agreement · 19

16 / Verb complementation and nonfinite clauses · 20

17 / Passive voice and information flow · 21

18 / Conditionals, remoteness and reporting · 22

19 / Prepositions, particles and lexical patterns · 23

20 / Coordination, subordination and punctuation · 24

Phonetics and phonology

21 / Speech, spelling and IPA notation · 25

22 / Articulation: place, manner and voicing · 26

23 / English consonant contrasts · 27

24 / Vowels and diphthongs · 28

Explained answers start on page 53. Glossary and references follow the answers.

Find a topic / 2 of 2

Each title below links to its topic. The PDF also includes section bookmarks.

25 / Phonemes, allophones and minimal pairs · 29

26 / Syllables, stress and schwa · 30

27 / Connected speech and grammatical endings · 31

28 / Intonation, prominence and accent choice · 32

Semantics

29 / Lexical meaning, sense and reference · 33

30 / Meaning relations and lexical ambiguity · 34

31 / Composition, entailment and contradiction · 35

32 / Quantifiers, negation and scope · 36

33 / Events, states and participant roles · 37

34 / Figurative meaning, collocation and semantic change · 38

Syntax

35 / Heads, dependents and constituents · 39

36 / Clause patterns, arguments and adjuncts · 40

37 / Finite, nonfinite and embedded clauses · 41

38 / Relative clauses and dependencies · 42

39 / Structural ambiguity and attachment · 43

40 / Fronting, inversion and information structure · 44

Pragmatics

41 / Context, deixis and common ground · 45

42 / Speech acts and indirect requests · 46

43 / Implicature and cancellable inference · 47

44 / Presupposition and backgrounded meaning · 48

45 / Politeness, stance and professional register · 49

46 / Discourse, cohesion and conversational repair · 50

Integrated analysis

47 / One sentence through six lenses · 51

48 / A diagnostic workshop and study plan · 52

Explained answers start on page 53. Glossary and references follow the answers.

Read, analyse, practise

Use the same small cycle at every level.

1 / Read	Read the explanation once for the overall distinction.
2 / Compare	Explain how the worked examples differ in form, meaning or use.
3 / Practise	Answer the two questions without looking at the key.
4 / Produce	Write or say two examples from your own life.
5 / Review	Check the explained answers and revise one example.

A course-aligned reading route

Starter: units 1, 4-8 and 21-22. Elementary: units 9-12, 15, 19-20 and 23-28. Intermediate: units 13-18, 29-31 and 35-38. Upper-intermediate and Advanced: units 32-34, 39-46. Use units 47-48 to connect the layers. These routes are suggestions; return to basic topics whenever a gap appears.

Conventions

/ /	Broad phonemic transcription: /pɪn/.
[ ]	A phonetic realisation: [pʰɪn]. In syntax, labelled brackets separately indicate constituency.
ˈ / ˌ / ː	Primary stress / secondary stress / length in the IPA conventions used here.
* / ?	A rejected standard-English reading / a doubtful or context-sensitive example.
[R1]-[R5]	Reference notes identifying further-reading resources at the end.

Use a notebook for extended practice. The PDF contains sound symbols and pronunciation guidance, but no embedded audio. Follow the official interactive IPA link to hear reference sounds; the course app provides lesson speech playback.

Descriptions use a standard-English teaching model and acknowledge variation. Technical analyses sometimes differ between linguistic theories; simplified NP and clause models here are tools for learning rather than claims that only one analysis is possible.

01 / Language as a system

All levels

Learning a language involves more than memorising translations. A speaker relates a physical signal to words, builds a structure and interprets that structure in a situation. These processes overlap, but separating them helps you diagnose a difficulty. If you know a word on paper but fail to recognise it in speech, the problem may concern sounds or segmentation rather than vocabulary.

Linguistics is the systematic study of language. Phonetics investigates how speech sounds are produced and perceived; phonology studies sound contrasts and patterns within a language. Morphology examines word structure. Syntax examines how words form phrases and clauses. Semantics examines meaning encoded by linguistic expressions. Pragmatics examines interpretation and action in context. These are analytical perspectives, not six isolated boxes: stress can affect what is communicated, and context can resolve structural ambiguity.

Grammar in everyday teaching often means a collection of correct forms. In linguistic description it includes systematic patterns that speakers use, whether or not they can explain a rule consciously. This book focuses on English, while introducing concepts that can also be used to compare languages.

Worked contrasts

Sound	ship and sheep differ in their vowel in many English accents.
Structure	The dog chased the child differs from The child chased the dog.
Context	It is cold here can describe a temperature or indirectly request action.

Watch the distinction
A sentence can be grammatical but unsuitable in a particular conversation. Conversely, an informal utterance can communicate perfectly without being a complete written sentence.

Check your understanding

1.1 Classify a problem with pronouncing /θ/: phonetics, syntax or semantics?

1.2 Give two possible interpretations of It is cold here.

02 / Description, variation and register

Elementary to Advanced

A descriptive statement explains a pattern found in a language variety. A prescriptive instruction tells a person which form to choose for a particular standard or institution. Both can be useful, but they answer different questions. The observation that a form occurs in conversation does not mean it is appropriate in a formal application; a school rule does not prove that all other varieties lack systematic grammar.

An accent primarily concerns pronunciation. A dialect can also differ in vocabulary and grammar. A register is a style associated with an activity, relationship or setting, such as a research article, a chat or a customer-service call. Variation is therefore not simply a ladder from bad to good English. Choose forms that suit the audience and purpose, while recognising that speakers may have more than one legitimate norm.

Compare I have not received your message with Haven’t got it yet. The second relies on shared context and omits an explicit subject. In a conversation this can be efficient; in a document it may require a fuller sentence. Formality is also not identical to politeness: a short, considerate response may be more helpful than an elaborate but dismissive one.

Worked contrasts

Accent	Different realisations of the vowel in bath.
Dialect	Different conventional grammatical or lexical patterns.
Register	Could you send the report? versus Send it over when you can.

Watch the distinction
Do not describe an accent as a speech defect or treat one national variety as the only real English. Aim for intelligibility and an appropriate register.

Check your understanding

2.1 Distinguish accent from register.

2.2 Rewrite Send me the file now for a polite professional message.

03 / Evidence, units and analytical tests

Pre-intermediate to Advanced

Language analysis begins with a question and a contrast. If you ask whether two words form a phrase, compare sentences in which they move together, replace them with another expression and examine how the meaning changes. If you ask whether a sound difference matters, look for words that differ only in that sound. A useful explanation should account for a pattern, not merely repeat the example.

Distinguish observations from interpretations. In The teacher near the windows is smiling, is agrees with teacher rather than windows. This is an observable pattern in standard English. One interpretation is that the phrase has an internal hierarchy with teacher as its head. Syntax uses such evidence to explain why the closest noun is not always the agreement controller.

Judgements depend on dialect, context and processing load. An unusual sentence is not automatically ungrammatical; an easily imagined sentence is not automatically natural. In this book, an asterisk marks a form rejected in the intended standard-English reading. A question mark indicates a context-sensitive or doubtful example. Real research also uses recorded speech, written corpora, experiments and comparison across speakers.

Worked contrasts

Observation	She smiles; they smile: the verb form changes.
Hypothesis	The finite verb agrees with the subject.
Counterexample to proximity	The teacher near the windows is smiling.

Watch the distinction
One test is rarely decisive. Use more than one diagnostic and state which reading or language variety you are testing.

Check your understanding

3.1 Choose the agreeing verb: The list of answers is/are short.

3.2 Why is a rare sentence not necessarily ungrammatical?

04 / Morphemes and word formation

Elementary to Advanced

A morpheme is a minimal unit associated with meaning or a grammatical function. In books, book contributes a lexical meaning and -s contributes plural number. A free morpheme can appear as a word; a bound morpheme must attach to something else. A root supplies a word’s core lexical material. An affix is an attached element, such as a prefix before a base or a suffix after it.

Inflection changes a word’s grammatical form without usually creating a new lexeme: book/books, walk/walked. Derivation creates a new lexeme and may change its category: happy/happiness; teach/teacher. A compound combines bases: classroom, coffee shop. Spacing is not a reliable test for compounds: some are written together, some separately and some with a hyphen.

A morpheme need not have one fixed pronunciation. English plural -s is pronounced /s/, /z/ or /ɪz/ depending on the preceding sound. These are allomorphs of the plural marker in a common analysis. Irregular plural mice is not created by adding the regular suffix. Word structure also has scope: unhappiness can be analysed as un- + happy first, with -ness forming the noun from unhappy.

Worked contrasts

Inflection	walk + -ed: past form of WALK.
Derivation	happy + -ness: a noun from an adjective.
Compound	coffee + shop: a type of shop.
Allomorphy	cats /s/, dogs /z/, buses /ɪz/.

Watch the distinction
Do not assume each letter corresponds to a morpheme or that every repeated ending has the same function. Teacher’s -er differs from the comparative -er in taller.

Check your understanding

4.1 Segment teachers into meaningful parts.

4.2 Is the -er in smaller the same kind of suffix as the -er in writer?

05 / Word classes and grammatical functions

Starter to Advanced

A word class describes the kinds of structures a word can enter. Nouns commonly head noun phrases; verbs head verb phrases; adjectives describe properties; adverbs modify verbs, adjectives, other adverbs or clauses. Determiners help specify a noun phrase, and prepositions relate their complement to something else. Conjunctions coordinate or introduce dependent structures. These are useful categories, but meaning alone is an unreliable test.

The word round can occur as an adjective in a round table, a preposition in round the corner in varieties that use that form, or a noun in another round. Its category depends on its use. Similarly, an action can be expressed by a noun such as movement. A better analysis combines meaning with distribution: where a word appears, which endings it accepts and what it can combine with.

A grammatical function is a role in a larger structure. Subject and object are functions, not word classes. The noun phrase The new student functions as the subject of The new student arrived and as the object of I welcomed the new student. A clause can also act as a subject: That she arrived early surprised us. Keeping category and function separate makes sentence analysis much clearer.

Worked contrasts

Noun phrase as subject	The new student arrived.
Noun phrase as object	I welcomed the new student.
Adjective as complement	The room is quiet.
Adverb modifying adjective	The room is unusually quiet.

Watch the distinction
Avoid defining the subject as the doer in every sentence. In The window was broken, the subject denotes the affected entity.

Check your understanding

5.1 Identify the category and function of the new student in I met the new student.

5.2 Identify what very modifies in very carefully.

06 / Nouns, number and countability

Starter to Intermediate

Count nouns can normally be counted directly and occur with a/an in the singular: a chair, three chairs. Noncount nouns generally require a unit expression or a different quantifier: some furniture, two pieces of furniture. Countability is a property of a particular use, not always an unchanging property of a word. Coffee can refer to a substance, while two coffees can mean two servings.

Use many and a few with plural count nouns; use much and a little with noncount nouns. Some and a lot of can occur with both. A few means a small number exists; few often presents the number as insufficient. The difference between a little and little works similarly. In questions, how many asks about countable items, while how much asks about an amount or a price.

English plurals include regular -s/-es forms and irregular forms such as children, men and mice. Some forms do not change, as in one sheep/two sheep. Standard English commonly treats information, advice and equipment as noncount: advice is useful, not an advice is useful. To count instances, use a piece of advice. The choice can vary by lexical sense, profession and variety, so learn examples in context.

Worked contrasts

Count	a suggestion / three suggestions
Noncount	some advice / a piece of advice
Shift in use	coffee as a drink / two coffees as servings
Evaluative contrast	a few answers: some; few answers: not many enough.

Watch the distinction
Do not add plural -s simply because a Turkish translation denotes several items. English noun behaviour must be learned with the English noun.

Check your understanding

6.1 Correct: I need an information.

6.2 Explain two possible uses of chicken as count and noncount.

07 / Articles, reference and determination

Starter to Advanced

Use a/an with a singular count noun to introduce an instance when the listener is not expected to identify a unique one: I bought a notebook. An depends on the following sound rather than spelling: an hour but a university. The indefinite article can also classify: She is a designer. It does not usually accompany plural or noncount nouns.

The often signals that the intended referent can be identified in the context. Identification can come from an earlier mention, a shared situation, a unique description or a conventional association. I bought a notebook. The notebook is blue uses earlier mention. Please close the door uses the shared setting. Identification does not always mean the item was mentioned before.

Zero article occurs in general statements with plural count nouns and many noncount nouns: Dogs need exercise; Water is essential. Compare The dogs need exercise, referring to an identifiable group. Article use also contains lexical conventions: go to school can describe institutional participation, while go to the school can identify a building. Proper names, countries and geographical names have patterns and exceptions. Avoid turning a useful tendency into a universal rule.

Worked contrasts

New instance	A student asked a question.
Identifiable referent	The student was sitting near me.
General category	Students need feedback.
Sound-based choice	an honest answer / a useful answer

Watch the distinction
Every singular count noun phrase does not need a/an specifically: my book, this book and the book use other determiners.

Check your understanding

7.1 Choose a/an: ___ hour; ___ university.

7.2 Explain the difference between Books are expensive and The books are expensive.

08 / Pronouns, case and reference

Starter to Upper-intermediate

Personal pronouns encode person and often number: I/we, you, he/she/it/they. Subject and object forms differ for several pronouns: I/me, he/him, she/her, we/us, they/them. Standard written English uses They invited me rather than They invited I. Possessive determiners appear with a noun, as in my book; independent possessive pronouns stand alone, as in The book is mine.

Reflexive forms such as myself and herself commonly relate an object to a subject within the same local clause: Ella introduced herself. They can also be emphatic: Ella herself wrote the report. A reflexive is not a generally more formal replacement for me. In ordinary standard usage, Please contact me is preferable to Please contact myself when no suitable local antecedent exists.

Pronouns require an interpretable referent, but that referent need not always be a previously mentioned noun. You and I are identified through the speech situation. It in It is raining has no ordinary object referent: it fills a grammatical position. Singular they can refer to a person whose gender is unknown or to a person who uses that pronoun. Its agreement remains they are, even with a singular individual reference.

Worked contrasts

Case	She helped him. He helped her.
Possession	my notes / these notes are mine
Reflexive	Maya reminded herself to practise.
Ambiguous reference	Sara called Lea when she arrived: clarify who arrived.

Watch the distinction
Its is possessive; it’s usually means it is or it has. Do not use an apostrophe simply to mark possession in its.

Check your understanding

8.1 Correct: Him gave the book to I.

8.2 What does it refer to in It is raining?

09 / Adjectives, adverbs and comparison

Elementary to Upper-intermediate

Adjectives can occur before a noun, as in a quiet room, or as a predicative complement, as in The room is quiet. Some adjectives are restricted: asleep is normally predicative, so the child is asleep is natural while an asleep child is unusual in ordinary standard usage. Adverbs have several jobs: carefully modifies an action; extremely modifies a degree; fortunately comments on a whole proposition.

Many adverbs end in -ly, but the ending is not a definition. Fast can be an adjective or adverb, and friendly is an adjective. Compare She looks careful, describing her appearance, with She looks carefully at the picture, describing the manner of looking. Choosing an adjective or adverb depends on the construction and the intended relationship.

Comparatives express a comparison, often with than: smaller than, more reliable than. Superlatives locate an item at an extreme within a comparison set: the smallest room, the most reliable method. Irregular patterns include good/better/best and bad/worse/worst. Short adjectives often take -er/-est; longer ones usually take more/most, with variation. Gradability is contextual: completely empty is conventional, while very empty may occur when a speaker treats emptiness as a scale.

Worked contrasts

Property versus manner	She is careful. She works carefully.
No -ly requirement	He runs fast.
Comparative	This explanation is clearer than that one.
Irregular	good / better / best

Watch the distinction
Avoid double comparatives such as more easier in standard usage. Some two-syllable adjectives permit more than one pattern.

Check your understanding

9.1 Correct: She speaks English fluent.

9.2 Rewrite This task is more easier.

10 / Verb forms, finiteness and auxiliaries

Elementary to Advanced

English verbs have several forms used in different constructions: base write; third-person singular writes; past wrote; past participle written; -ing form writing. A finite verb carries a tense or is a finite modal and participates in clause-level agreement or inversion patterns. Nonfinite forms include to write, write after a modal, writing and written in appropriate constructions.

Auxiliaries contribute grammatical information and support operations such as negation and questions. Be marks the progressive in is writing and participates in passives such as was written. Have marks the perfect in has written. Do supplies support when the relevant clause has no other finite auxiliary: She writes becomes Does she write? The auxiliary carries the finite marking; the lexical verb returns to its base form.

A verb group can contain several layers. In She might have been working, might is the finite modal, have introduces the perfect and been introduces the progressive construction with working. Interpret the entire group rather than translating each word separately. Be, have and do can also be lexical verbs: I have a bicycle; I do my homework. Their status depends on the construction.

Worked contrasts

Base after do	Does she write? / She does not write.
Perfect	She has written three pages.
Progressive	She is writing now.
Layered form	She might have been working.

Watch the distinction
The word after a modal is normally a base form: can swim, not can swims. In a multi-verb sequence, not every verb carries tense.

Check your understanding

10.1 Correct: Did he went home?

10.2 Identify the finite verb in They have been waiting.

11 / Tense, time and aspect

Elementary to Advanced

Tense is a grammatical category; time is what we locate an event or state in. English has a contrast between present and past finite forms, while future reference is expressed through several constructions, including will, be going to and a present form. Teaching labels such as future perfect are useful construction names, but they should not imply that English has a separate inflected future form.

Aspect presents an event from a particular viewpoint. The progressive, be + -ing, presents a situation as ongoing around a reference point: I am reading; I was reading at eight. The perfect, have + past participle, relates an earlier situation to a reference point: I have finished; I had finished before she arrived. These grammatical choices interact with lexical meaning and context.

Present forms do not always describe the present moment. The train leaves tomorrow can refer to a scheduled future. Past forms can mark remoteness rather than past time: If I knew the answer describes a present hypothetical situation. Conversely, a historical present can narrate a past story vividly. Ask three questions when choosing a construction: What is the reference time? How is the situation viewed? What connection matters to the listener? [R2]

Worked contrasts

Past time	I left yesterday.
Scheduled future	The lesson starts tomorrow.
Present hypothetical	If I knew, I would tell you.
Perfect relative to past	I had finished before the meeting started.

Watch the distinction
Do not identify tense solely from words like tomorrow or yesterday. Those locate time; the grammatical form and discourse use must also be analysed.

Check your understanding

11.1 What is the morphological tense in The train leaves tomorrow?

11.2 Explain the contrast between I read the report and I was reading the report when she called.

12 / Present simple and progressive

Elementary to Intermediate

The present simple commonly describes habits, stable situations, generalisations and schedules: I work in a school; Water freezes at suitable temperatures; The class starts at nine. It does not mean that every present-simple situation is permanent. The third-person singular normally has -s, but questions and negatives use does + base form: Does she work? She does not work.

The present progressive commonly describes an ongoing, temporary or changing situation: I am working from home this week; Your English is improving. It can express an arranged future: We are meeting on Friday. With always and similar adverbs it may express an attitude to a repeated behaviour: You are always interrupting me. The meaning is not simply happening right this second.

Stative uses, such as knowing an answer or owning a house, often favour the simple form, but a verb can have different senses. I think you are right expresses an opinion; I am thinking about the problem expresses an ongoing mental activity. I have a car expresses possession; I am having lunch uses have in a different construction. Learn the meaning-and-construction pair rather than a rule that a whole word can never appear in the progressive.

Worked contrasts

Habit	She reads every evening.
Temporary situation	She is reading a long novel this week.
Opinion versus activity	I think it is useful. / I am thinking about it.
Arrangement	We are meeting tomorrow.

Watch the distinction
Use an auxiliary in the progressive: She is studying, not She studying. After does, remove the third-person -s from the lexical verb.

Check your understanding

12.1 Choose a form: I usually walk/am walking to school.

12.2 Explain why I am having lunch is possible although I have a bicycle uses a simple form.

13 / Past narration and the perfect

Pre-intermediate to Advanced

The past simple usually places a situation in a finished past frame: We met last Monday. The past progressive supplies an ongoing background: I was cooking when the phone rang. The past perfect locates an earlier situation relative to a later past point: By the time I arrived, the meeting had ended. Once the ordering is clear, a narrative does not need the past perfect in every sentence.

The present perfect connects an earlier situation with a present reference point. It can describe experience without a specified finished occasion, a continuing period or a relevant result: I have visited Rome; I have lived here for three years; I have lost my keys. Standard usage usually avoids a finished-time adverbial such as yesterday with the present perfect. Use I saw her yesterday.

For indicates duration; since identifies a starting point. I have been studying for two hours emphasises an ongoing or recently ongoing activity. I have written two pages emphasises a result or quantity. These are tendencies, not mechanically interchangeable translations. American and British usage can differ, especially with just, already and yet. Choose a consistent learning model while recognising other conventional varieties.

Worked contrasts

Finished occasion	I saw her yesterday.
Continuing period	I have lived here since 2022.
Background plus event	I was reading when he arrived.
Activity versus result	I have been writing. / I have written two pages.

Watch the distinction
Present perfect does not always mean the event is recent. It can refer to an experience many years ago if the current frame is relevant.

Check your understanding

13.1 Correct: I have met her yesterday.

13.2 Order the events in The bus had left before I reached the stop.

14 / Future reference and modality

Pre-intermediate to Advanced

Future reference can be expressed by will, going to, present progressive or present simple, depending on the context. Will can make a prediction, a promise or an immediate decision. Going to often presents an earlier intention or a prediction based on current evidence. The progressive commonly presents an arrangement, while the simple commonly presents a schedule. These are overlapping uses, not four perfectly separate boxes.

Modality expresses judgements about possibility, necessity, permission, ability or obligation. Epistemic uses concern what may or must be true: She must be at home is an inference. Deontic uses concern requirements or permissions: You must wear a badge is an obligation. The same modal can therefore have different interpretations, and context determines which one is intended.

Modals are followed by a base form: might come, should study. Must not usually expresses prohibition, while do not have to expresses lack of obligation. Modal + have + past participle locates an evaluation before the reference time: She may have left; You should have called. Should have called usually criticises or regrets an unrealised past action, while may have left leaves the actual event uncertain.

Worked contrasts

Plan	I am going to take a course.
Arrangement	I am meeting the tutor on Friday.
Inference	The lights are on; she must be home.
Obligation contrast	You must not leave. / You do not have to stay.

Watch the distinction
Could does not simply equal the past of can in every use. It can express a present possibility or a polite request.

Check your understanding

14.1 Explain must not versus do not have to.

14.2 Does She might have left assert that she left?

15 / Negation, questions and agreement

Elementary to Advanced

In a standard yes/no question, a finite auxiliary usually precedes the subject: Is she ready? Has she left? Can she swim? Without another auxiliary, use do: Does she work here? Negation generally follows the finite auxiliary: She is not ready; She does not work here. With be as a copular verb, no do-support is needed: Is he tired?

Wh-questions ask for a missing component: Where does she work? A subject question usually does not require do-support: Who called you? Compare Who did you call?, where who is the object. Embedded questions use statement order: I wonder where she works, not I wonder where does she work. Indirectness can change the structure as well as the social effect.

Agreement normally relates the finite verb to the subject: The list of names is long. The head list matters, not the nearby plural names. Collective nouns can vary across varieties and interpretations. Negative words also interact with dialect: standard formal English commonly uses I did not see anybody or I saw nobody. Varieties with negative concord have systematic patterns, but this book’s formal-writing model follows standard usage.

Worked contrasts

Yes/no	Does she know?
Subject wh-question	Who knows the answer?
Object wh-question	Who did she invite?
Embedded question	Can you tell me where she lives?

Watch the distinction
Avoid adding a second past marker after did: Did she leave?, not Did she left? Agreement is structural, not simply based on the closest noun.

Check your understanding

15.1 Correct: Do you know where is the station?

15.2 Make a question about the subject in Maya called Ben.

16 / Verb complementation and nonfinite clauses

Pre-intermediate to Advanced

Verbs license particular complements. Enjoy commonly takes an -ing clause: I enjoy reading. Decide commonly takes a to-infinitival clause: I decided to read. Tell can take an object followed by a to-infinitive: She told me to wait. These patterns are part of the lexical knowledge associated with a verb; they cannot all be predicted from an English-to-Turkish translation.

Some verbs admit different complements with different meanings. Remember locking the door concerns a memory of an earlier action; remember to lock the door concerns remembering a required action. Stop smoking means cease smoking; stop to smoke means interrupt another activity in order to smoke. An -ing form is therefore not automatically a noun, and a to-infinitive does not always indicate future time.

Nonfinite clauses often have an understood subject. In Maya promised to leave, Maya is understood as the person leaving. In Maya persuaded Ben to leave, Ben is understood as leaving. The difference comes from the matrix verb’s construction. A passive can change the form without changing that relationship: Ben was persuaded to leave. Learn the whole pattern, including any object, rather than memorising a single verb ending.

Worked contrasts

Verb pattern	enjoy reading / decide to read
Memory versus duty	remember locking / remember to lock
Cease versus purpose	stop smoking / stop to smoke
Understood subject	Maya persuaded Ben to leave: Ben leaves.

Watch the distinction
After a preposition, an -ing clause is common: interested in learning; before leaving. But to can be a preposition in look forward to learning.

Check your understanding

16.1 Correct: I enjoy to read.

16.2 Who is expected to leave in Lea persuaded Omar to leave?

17 / Passive voice and information flow

Intermediate to Advanced

The passive commonly uses be + past participle: The report was written yesterday. The entity expressed as the active object can become the passive subject: Someone repaired the bicycle becomes The bicycle was repaired. The doer can be expressed with by, but it can be omitted when unknown, obvious or irrelevant. Passive voice changes grammatical organisation; it does not necessarily change what happened.

Tense and aspect are marked through the auxiliary sequence: is repaired, was repaired, is being repaired, has been repaired, may be repaired. The lexical participle does not alone determine time. Some verbs do not normally passivise because their constructions lack a suitable object: arrived does not ordinarily produce was arrived. Some by-phrases are natural; others sound odd when they add no useful information.

Passives can keep a familiar topic in subject position and introduce new information later. They are useful in process descriptions and reports but can also obscure responsibility when an agent matters. A participial form may instead describe a state: The door is closed can describe a condition or a passive event, depending on context. Get-passives, as in He got promoted, are common in less formal usage and have their own nuances.

Worked contrasts

Active	The technician repaired the screen.
Passive	The screen was repaired by the technician.
Progressive passive	The screen is being repaired.
Perfect passive	The screen has been repaired.

Watch the distinction
Being and been are different forms. Use is being repaired for an ongoing process and has been repaired for a perfect construction.

Check your understanding

17.1 Make passive: Someone has cleaned the room.

17.2 Why might a report retain a by-phrase?

18 / Conditionals, remoteness and reporting

Intermediate to Advanced

Conditional clauses connect a condition to a consequence, but the relationship can concern events, reasoning or conversational relevance. If it rains, we will stay inside presents a possible future; If I knew the answer, I would tell you presents a remote hypothetical. Past form in knew does not locate that hypothetical knowing in the past. Conventional first/second/third labels are useful practice patterns, not an exhaustive inventory.

Past counterfactuals typically combine if + past perfect with would have + participle: If I had left earlier, I would have arrived on time. Mixed patterns connect different reference times: If I had taken that course, I would know more now. Unless often means if not, but its use should be checked against the intended logic rather than substituted blindly into every negative condition.

Reporting can change tense, pronouns and expressions of time or place because the reporting viewpoint changes. She said, I am tired can become She said that she was tired. Backshift is common after a past reporting verb, but need not be obligatory when the proposition remains valid or the speaker deliberately retains its current relevance. Reported questions use statement order, and commands can use an infinitive: She asked me to wait.

Worked contrasts

Possible future	If she calls, I will answer.
Remote present	If I had time, I would help.
Past to present	If I had studied it, I would understand it now.
Reported question	He asked where I lived.

Watch the distinction
Would is not normally used in the if-clause of a basic hypothetical pattern, though special willingness and politeness uses exist.

Check your understanding

18.1 Complete: If I had known, I ___ told you.

18.2 Report Where do you live? after He asked me.

19 / Prepositions, particles and lexical patterns

Elementary to Advanced

A preposition typically takes a complement and heads a phrase that expresses a relationship: in the room, after the lesson, with a friend. Its meaning can be spatial, temporal or abstract. In, on and at are useful starting points for time and location, but English contains many conventional combinations: interested in, responsible for, depend on. Knowing the general meaning does not automatically predict every lexical choice.

Particles occur in multiword verb constructions such as turn off and give up. In a common separable pattern, a full noun phrase can precede or follow the particle: turn off the light; turn the light off. A short object pronoun normally precedes it: turn it off, not turn off it in the intended construction. Other combinations are not separable: look after the child, not look the child after.

An expression can be literal or idiomatic. Look up can describe directing the eyes upward; look up a word means consult a reference. Formality also varies: find out may be natural in a conversation while determine suits some reports. Learn meaning, complement pattern, separability and register together. In syntax, analyses of particles and prepositions differ, so the traditional teaching label phrasal verb is a practical umbrella rather than a complete theory.

Worked contrasts

Time	at 6 pm / on Monday / in October
Lexical selection	interested in learning / responsible for planning
Separable	turn the radio off / turn it off
Not separable	look after the child / look after her

Watch the distinction
Avoid translating a preposition directly from another language. A word may select a different pattern in English.

Check your understanding

19.1 Correct: Turn off it.

19.2 Give the preposition: She is interested ___ linguistics.

20 / Coordination, subordination and punctuation

Pre-intermediate to Advanced

Coordination connects expressions of comparable status: Maya and Ben; tired but happy; I called and she answered. Subordination makes one clause dependent on another: I left because I was tired; Although it rained, we walked. The same meaning relationship can be expressed through different structures, but a conjunction and a sentence adverb do not behave identically.

Because introduces a subordinate clause. Therefore relates a proposition to an earlier one but does not by itself coordinate two independent clauses. Compare I was tired, so I left with I was tired; therefore, I left. A comma alone between two independent clauses is often treated as a comma splice in formal writing. Use a full stop, a semicolon or an appropriate coordinator when the structure requires it.

Relative clauses modify a nominal expression: the book that I bought. Supplementary relatives add a separate comment and are often marked with commas: Maya, who lives nearby, helped us. Punctuation is therefore connected to meaning, not merely breathing. A restrictive relative identifies which referent is meant; a supplementary relative adds information about an already identifiable referent. In speech, phrasing and intonation may indicate the distinction.

Worked contrasts

Coordination	I checked the file, and she sent it.
Subordination	I sent it because she needed it.
Sentence adverb	She needed it; therefore, I sent it.
Relative distinction	Students who arrived early helped. / Maya, who arrived early, helped.

Watch the distinction
A comma is not a universal sign for any pause. Structure, meaning and the relevant writing convention should guide punctuation.

Check your understanding

20.1 Repair the formal-writing comma splice: It rained, we stayed home.

20.2 Does Students who arrived early helped necessarily mean every student arrived early?

21 / Speech, spelling and IPA notation

Starter to Advanced

Written letters and spoken sounds are different systems. A letter can correspond to several sounds, and a sound can be represented by several spellings. The letters th can represent /θ/ in thin or /ð/ in this. The sound /f/ occurs in fish and phone. Counting letters is therefore not a dependable way to count phonemes.

The International Phonetic Alphabet provides symbols for speech sounds. Slashes conventionally indicate a phonemic representation, such as /pɪn/. Square brackets indicate a phonetic realisation, which may include more detail, such as [pʰɪn] with aspiration. The symbol ˈ precedes primary stress; ˌ marks secondary stress; ː marks length in transcriptions that use it. Learn symbols with sounds and articulatory descriptions, not as alternative spelling. [R1]

Transcriptions depend on the chosen accent and level of detail. This book mainly uses broad, traditional dictionary-style southern British examples, with selected General American comparisons. These are teaching reference models, not claims about how everyone in Britain or America speaks. Different dictionaries may use different conventions for closely related vowels. A transcription that differs from the model is not necessarily wrong.

Worked contrasts

Spelling versus sound	phone begins with /f/, although it starts with two letters.
Phonemic	pin /pɪn/: a representation of contrastive units.
Phonetic	[pʰɪn]: a possible more detailed pronunciation.
Primary stress	about /əˈbaʊt/: stress precedes the second syllable.

Watch the distinction
IPA symbols should not be read as their names in the ordinary alphabet. /j/ represents the initial sound of yes, not the initial sound of job.

Check your understanding

21.1 What does /j/ represent in English?

21.2 What is the usual distinction between / / and [ ]?

22 / Articulation: place, manner and voicing

Elementary to Advanced

Speech production involves airflow, the larynx and articulators such as lips, tongue and teeth. For many consonants, three questions are useful: Where is the constriction? How does air pass through it? Are the vocal folds vibrating? These correspond to place, manner and voicing. The categories describe a sound, not the shape of its written letter.

Place includes bilabial at the two lips, labiodental at lower lip and upper teeth, dental near the teeth, alveolar at the ridge behind the upper teeth, postalveolar behind that ridge, palatal at the hard palate and velar at the soft palate. A glottal sound involves the laryngeal region. Manner distinguishes complete closure in stops, narrow turbulent airflow in fricatives, a stop-plus-frication sequence in affricates, nasal airflow in nasals and less obstructed airflow in approximants.

Voicing can contrast sounds made with broadly similar oral gestures: /f/ versus /v/, /s/ versus /z/. Feel vibration at your throat while prolonging /z/, then compare /s/. English contrasts are not explained by vibration alone: timing, aspiration and other cues also matter. A whisper can remove ordinary vocal-fold vibration while listeners still use other cues to recognise words. Avoid reducing the entire consonant system to a simplistic voiced/unvoiced label.

Worked contrasts

Bilabial stop	/p/ in pin; /b/ in bin.
Labiodental fricative	/f/ in fan; /v/ in van.
Alveolar nasal	/n/ in no.
Velar nasal	/ŋ/ at the end of sing.

Watch the distinction
For /ŋ/, the back of the tongue contacts the soft-palate area. Do not automatically add /g/ to sing in the reference models used here.

Check your understanding

22.1 Describe /f/ by place, manner and voicing.

22.2 How does a nasal differ from an oral stop in airflow?

23 / English consonant contrasts

Elementary to Advanced

Learn consonants through contrasts in real words. Fan/van, sip/zip and thin/tin help you hear differences that may not match the categories of your first language. For /θ/, place the tongue lightly at or near the teeth and allow friction without vocal-fold vibration; /ð/ uses a related gesture with voicing in typical sustained production. The target is not a forceful bite or an exaggerated tongue movement.

The reference consonant set includes stops /p b t d k g/, fricatives /f v θ ð s z ʃ ʒ h/, affricates /tʃ dʒ/, nasals /m n ŋ/ and approximants /r j w l/. Dictionaries often use /r/ as a convenient phonemic symbol; a common English realisation is [ɹ], not the trill denoted by IPA [r]. Actual pronunciations vary with accent and context.

Affricates combine a closure and a fricative release as a unit in many analyses: /tʃ/ in chair and /dʒ/ in job. Distinguish /ʃ/ in ship from /tʃ/ in chip; the latter starts with a closure. Clusters also matter: school begins with /sk/, not a vowel followed by /sk/. Practise slowly enough to notice the gestures, then integrate them into normal phrases rather than permanently speaking each sound in isolation.

Worked contrasts

Voicing contrast	fan /fæn/ - van /væn/
Dental versus alveolar	thin /θɪn/ - tin /tɪn/
Fricative versus affricate	ship /ʃɪp/ - chip /tʃɪp/
Cluster	school /sku:l/ in a broad dictionary transcription.

Watch the distinction
A written ng does not always have one pronunciation. Compare sing, singer and finger in your chosen dictionary and accent model.

Check your understanding

23.1 Which word starts with an affricate: ship or chip?

23.2 Why can IPA /r/ in a dictionary differ from a detailed [ɹ]?

24 / Vowels and diphthongs

Elementary to Advanced

Vowels are commonly described through tongue height, tongue backness and lip rounding. High or close vowels involve a relatively raised tongue; low or open vowels a lower tongue. Front, central and back refer to the tongue’s horizontal position. These descriptions are approximations of a complex articulatory and acoustic system, not instructions to place the tongue at one exact visible point.

Compare /iː/ in fleece, /ɪ/ in kit, /e/ in dress, /æ/ in trap, /ʌ/ in strut and /ə/ in an unstressed syllable of about in a traditional southern British model. Other useful reference vowels include /ɑː/ in palm, /ɒ/ in lot, /ɔː/ in thought, /ʊ/ in foot, /uː/ in goose and /ɜː/ in nurse. The lexical keywords are more reliable than an assumption that all accents share the same set.

A diphthong changes quality within one syllable, such as /aɪ/ in price or /aʊ/ in mouth. British-style /əʊ/ in goat often corresponds to an American-style /oʊ/ transcription. Some American varieties merge lot and thought; rhotic varieties have an /r/-related realisation in nurse. Length alone does not explain sheep/ship: vowel quality also differs. For practical learning, listen to minimal pairs from one model before comparing accents.

Worked contrasts

Quality contrast	ship /ʃɪp/ - sheep /ʃiːp/
Rounding contrast	/uː/ typically has more rounding than /iː/.
Diphthong	price /praɪs/; mouth /maʊθ/.
Accent convention	goat: /gəʊt/ in one British model, /goʊt/ in an American model.

Watch the distinction
There is no single accent-independent number of English vowels. Do not describe all vowels simply as short or long versions of the same sound.

Check your understanding

24.1 Is the contrast between ship and sheep only duration?

24.2 What does a diphthong change within a syllable?

25 / Phonemes, allophones and minimal pairs

Pre-intermediate to Advanced

A phoneme is a contrastive category in a language system. If replacing one sound with another can distinguish words, the difference can support a phonemic contrast. Pin/bin is a minimal pair in the relevant English models: it differs in one segment and has two lexical meanings. Minimal-pair evidence must be interpreted within a variety, since different accents can have different contrasts.

An allophone is a context-dependent realisation of a phoneme in an analysis. English /p/ is commonly aspirated at the start of a stressed syllable, as in pin, but less aspirated after /s/, as in spin. A broad transcription can treat both as /p/; a narrower transcription may represent [pʰ] and [p]. The difference is not normally a word-meaning contrast in English, though aspiration is contrastive in some other languages.

Predictable distribution provides evidence for an allophonic relationship, but complementary distribution alone is not a sufficient automatic test: phonetic similarity and the wider system also matter. Phonological analysis abstracts from continuous physical variation. It does not say every speaker produces an identical sound. Learning requires both noticing meaningful contrasts and becoming familiar with their normal contextual realisations.

Worked contrasts

Minimal pair	pin /pɪn/ - bin /bɪn/
Contrast	The initial difference can change the word.
Allophones	Commonly aspirated [pʰ] in pin; less aspirated [p] in spin.
Language-specific status	A difference predictable in one language may distinguish words in another.

Watch the distinction
Minimal pairs need the same surrounding sound sequence. A pair differing in several sounds is not a strict minimal pair.

Check your understanding

25.1 Are cat and dog a minimal pair?

25.2 Why are [pʰ] and [p] not usually two separate English phonemes in the examples above?

26 / Syllables, stress and schwa

Elementary to Advanced

A syllable is often analysed into an onset, a nucleus and a coda. In cat, /k/ is the onset, /æ/ the nucleus and /t/ the coda. A nucleus is commonly a vowel, though some accents and styles permit syllabic consonants, as in certain pronunciations of little. English allows clusters such as /str/ in street, but not every imaginable consonant sequence is permitted in every syllable position.

Stress makes a syllable prominent relative to others through several cues, including duration, pitch and vowel quality. English word stress can distinguish a noun from a related verb in some pairs: a REcord versus to reCORD. Not every noun/verb pair behaves this way. Written capital letters here show emphasis for teaching; IPA stress marks precede the stressed syllable.

Schwa /ə/ is a common central vowel in unstressed syllables, such as the first syllable of about. Unstressed grammatical words may also have reduced forms: can can be /kən/ in a phrase where it is not prominent, rather than a strong /kæn/. Reduction depends on emphasis, position, variety and speaking style. Learning only the isolated strong form makes normal connected speech harder to recognise. Do not reduce a word mechanically when it needs contrastive emphasis.

Worked contrasts

Syllable structure	cat: onset /k/, nucleus /æ/, coda /t/.
Cluster	street has a complex onset.
Word stress	a REcord / to reCORD in common reference pronunciations.
Reduction	I can go: can may be weak /kən/.

Watch the distinction
Stress does not mean shouting every consonant. Attend to the prominent syllable and the quality of neighbouring unstressed vowels.

Check your understanding

26.1 Identify the onset, nucleus and coda of /sɪt/.

26.2 Why might can sound different in I can go and Yes, I CAN?

27 / Connected speech and grammatical endings

Elementary to Advanced

Words in fluent speech influence their neighbours. Assimilation makes a sound more similar to an adjacent sound, as when the nasal in ten boys may be produced with a bilabial gesture. Elision omits a segment in some contexts and styles. Linking connects words smoothly without inserting a full pause at each written boundary. These processes are variable, not requirements to swallow sounds indiscriminately.

English grammatical endings show sound-conditioned patterns. Regular plural and third-person singular -s are commonly /s/ after voiceless nonsibilants, /z/ after voiced nonsibilants and /ɪz/ after sibilants. Thus cats, dogs and buses illustrate three realisations. Some accents use a vowel closer to [ə] in the added syllable. The relevant trigger is the preceding sound, not the final written letter.

Regular past -ed is commonly /t/ after voiceless sounds other than /t/, /d/ after voiced sounds other than /d/, and /ɪd/ after /t/ or /d/. Compare worked, played and wanted. The added vowel usually creates another syllable only in the last group. A few adjectives have conventional special pronunciations. First learn the regular productive pattern, then check exceptional lexical items rather than applying one pronunciation to every -ed spelling.

Worked contrasts

Plural /s/	cats /kæts/
Plural /z/	dogs /dɒgz/ in the British model
Extra syllable	buses /ˈbʌsɪz/
Past endings	worked /t/, played /d/, wanted /ɪd/ at the ending.

Watch the distinction
Added vowels inside clusters can make words harder to recognise. Practise ending consonants in phrases, not just isolated words.

Check your understanding

27.1 Choose the -ed ending in washed: /t/, /d/ or /ɪd/.

27.2 Which has an added plural syllable: books or watches?

28 / Intonation, prominence and accent choice

Pre-intermediate to Advanced

Intonation is the organisation of pitch across an utterance. Prominence highlights material important to the speaker’s message. I ordered the GREEN notebook contrasts its colour; I ORDERED the green notebook may contrast ordering with merely looking at it. These contrasts depend on a plausible context. The sentence’s word sequence can remain the same while the information presented as new or corrective changes.

Pitch movement can signal completion, continuation, uncertainty, engagement or other stances, but one contour does not have one universal meaning. A rising contour does not automatically make an utterance a question, and a falling contour does not always make it a statement. Variety, discourse position and social interpretation all matter. Learn contours through short contextualised exchanges rather than a rigid rule for every punctuation mark.

Choose a pronunciation model to make practice consistent, then develop listening flexibility. Rhotic accents generally pronounce an /r/-related sound in words such as car; nonrhotic models do not usually pronounce it unless the phonological context supports linking. Differences in vowels, flapping, glottal realisation or rhythm are patterns of variation, not evidence of lower intelligence. The practical aim is clear communication and recognition of common variants.

Worked contrasts

Contrastive prominence	I wanted the BLUE one, not the green one.
Given versus new	Which notebook? / The GREEN notebook.
Context-sensitive pitch	You finished? can function as a checking question.
Accent pattern	Car differs in rhotic and nonrhotic reference models.

Watch the distinction
Intonation cannot be accurately learned from capitals alone. Use audio, a teacher or a pronunciation resource to hear the pitch movement.

Check your understanding

28.1 What might prominence on green communicate?

28.2 Does a rising pitch always mark a grammatical question?

29 / Lexical meaning, sense and reference

Elementary to Advanced

Semantics studies meaning associated with linguistic expressions and how meanings combine. A word’s sense is related to its conventional content and relations to other expressions. Its reference concerns the entity or entities it picks out in a particular interpretation. The same referent can be described in different ways: the class tutor and the person who emailed you may identify one individual while presenting different information.

A noun such as dog can denote a category, while a phrase such as that dog can identify an individual in context. A proper name can also require contextual disambiguation: there may be many people called Maya. Definitions are useful, but lexical knowledge includes selection patterns, typical uses, connotations and relations to other words. Knowing a word does not mean knowing one fixed object that it always points to.

A distinction between extension and intension can help at an advanced level. Extension concerns the entities or truth values an expression has relative to a situation; intension concerns how that extension varies across possible circumstances in a formal analysis. The extension of the tallest student can change if the class changes, while the descriptive way of identifying that person stays recognisable. Different semantic theories formalise these ideas differently.

Worked contrasts

Same reference, different description	the tutor / the person who emailed you
Category versus individual	dog / that dog
Contextual disambiguation	Maya: which person with that name?
Changing extension	the tallest student can identify different people in different classes.

Watch the distinction
Meaning is not identical to a mental picture. Abstract terms, quantifiers and logical words are meaningful without naming a visible object.

Check your understanding

29.1 Can two different descriptions identify the same person?

29.2 Does the word dog always refer to one particular animal?

30 / Meaning relations and lexical ambiguity

Pre-intermediate to Advanced

Synonymy concerns similar meanings; complete interchangeability in every context is rare. Begin and commence overlap, but register and collocation differ. Hyponymy is a kind-of relationship: a poodle is a dog, and a dog is an animal. Meronymy is a part-of relationship: a wheel is part of a bicycle. These relations organise vocabulary more effectively than an unstructured translation list.

Antonymy includes different patterns. Gradable opposites such as hot/cold permit intermediate values and degree modifiers. Complementary opposites in a suitable fixed domain, such as alive/dead in an ordinary biological classification, do not work like an ordinary temperature scale. Relational converses such as buy/sell or parent/child describe a relationship from different participant perspectives.

Lexical ambiguity occurs when a form has more than one meaning. Polysemy involves related senses, such as a person’s head and the head of a department. Homonymy concerns unrelated meanings sharing a form, such as bank as a financial institution and bank beside a river. The boundary can depend on historical and analytical assumptions. Context often chooses a sense, but deliberate wordplay may keep more than one interpretation active.

Worked contrasts

Hyponymy	poodle is a kind of dog.
Meronymy	a wheel is part of a bicycle.
Converse relation	Lea sold it to Ben / Ben bought it from Lea.
Ambiguous word	We waited near the bank.

Watch the distinction
A dictionary with two numbered senses does not by itself settle whether the meanings are psychologically or historically related.

Check your understanding

30.1 Classify wheel/bicycle: kind-of or part-of?

30.2 Give two interpretations of We waited near the bank.

31 / Composition, entailment and contradiction

Intermediate to Advanced

Compositionality is the idea that the meaning of a complex expression depends systematically on its parts and how they are combined. The order in Lea followed Ben matters because it identifies participant roles. Nonliteral uses and idioms complicate a simple word-by-word approach, but systematic combination remains central to ordinary interpretation.

A proposition is content that can be evaluated as true or false relative to a situation. One proposition entails another if, whenever the first is true in the relevant interpretation, the second must also be true. Lea owns a poodle entails Lea owns a dog, assuming the ordinary category relation. The converse does not hold: owning a dog does not entail owning a poodle. Entailment is about the relationship between contents, not about whether we personally believe the first claim.

Contradiction occurs when propositions cannot both be true in the intended interpretation: The room is empty and At least one person is in the room conflict if empty is defined as containing no people and both concern the same room and time. Real language requires careful control of time, sense and domain. A room can be empty of furniture while containing a person. Always state the interpretation instead of assuming every apparent conflict is logical.

Worked contrasts

One-way entailment	owns a poodle => owns a dog.
No reverse entailment	owns a dog does not guarantee owns a poodle.
Structure matters	Lea followed Ben differs from Ben followed Lea.
Domain matters	empty of furniture is not identical to empty of people.

Watch the distinction
Entailment is not a guess about what probably happened. A probable consequence is weaker than a consequence guaranteed by the content.

Check your understanding

31.1 Does Lea owns a dog entail Lea owns an animal?

31.2 Does Lea owns an animal entail Lea owns a dog?

32 / Quantifiers, negation and scope

Upper-intermediate to Advanced

Quantifiers describe amounts or relationships between sets: some, every, no, most and exactly three. Every student passed asserts that each member of the relevant student set passed. Some student passed requires at least one in an ordinary existential reading. The relevant domain is supplied by context: every student can mean every student in this class rather than every student in the world.

Scope determines which operator is interpreted as applying over which part of a proposition. Every student read a book can describe one shared book or potentially different books for different students. A paraphrase such as There is one book that every student read selects the shared-book reading. A paraphrase such as Each student read at least one book leaves the books free to differ.

Negation makes scope especially important. Not every student passed means it is not the case that all passed; it does not assert that none passed. No student passed means none did. A modal also interacts with negation: You do not have to leave denies necessity; You must not leave imposes a negative obligation. When an instruction, contract or claim is important, rewrite scope ambiguities explicitly rather than trusting a vague sentence.

Worked contrasts

Existential	Some student passed: at least one.
Partial negation	Not every student passed: at least one did not.
Total negative	No student passed: none did.
Scope contrast	one shared book / possibly a different book per student

Watch the distinction
Some often suggests not all in conversation, but its basic at-least-one content does not by itself require that interpretation. See the implicature section.

Check your understanding

32.1 Does Not every student passed mean No student passed?

32.2 Give a clear paraphrase for the shared-book reading of Every student read a book.

33 / Events, states and participant roles

Intermediate to Advanced

A predicate relates participants or attributes a property. In Maya opened the door, the event has an agent and a theme or affected entity in a common analysis. In Maya heard a noise, Maya is an experiencer rather than an intentional agent. Participant roles describe how entities are involved in a situation; subject and object describe grammatical functions. The two should not be treated as identical.

Lexical aspect concerns the temporal organisation associated with a predicate and its arguments. Know the answer describes a state. Run in the park can describe an activity without a built-in endpoint. Write a letter commonly has an endpoint when the letter is complete. Reach the summit highlights an attainment. These labels are analytical tools, and a predicate’s classification can change with its arguments and context.

Telicity concerns an inherent endpoint. Run for an hour gives a duration to an otherwise atelic activity; write the letter in an hour measures time to a completion. These adverbial tendencies are diagnostics, not infallible tests. If I was writing the letter, it does not follow that I finished it. The progressive can present an event internally without asserting its culmination. This helps explain why tense choice alone cannot determine whether a task was completed.

Worked contrasts

Agent and theme	Maya opened the door.
Experiencer	Maya heard a noise.
State	know the answer
Endpoint contrast	run in the park / write the letter

Watch the distinction
A passive subject may be a theme, and an active subject may be an experiencer. Subject does not universally mean agent.

Check your understanding

33.1 Does I was writing the letter entail that I completed it?

33.2 What role does Maya have in Maya heard a noise?

34 / Figurative meaning, collocation and semantic change

Intermediate to Advanced

Figurative language relies on relationships beyond a literal interpretation. A metaphor presents one domain through another: That proposal is a bridge can frame the proposal as connecting two positions. A metonymy uses an associated entity to identify another: The classroom applauded can refer to its occupants. Interpretation depends on context and conventions; not every imaginative comparison has one fixed hidden meaning.

Collocation is a tendency for words to occur together: make a decision, heavy rain, strong evidence. A combination can be grammatical yet less conventional, as in powerful rain in an ordinary weather report. Selection restrictions concern compatibility between a predicate and its arguments in a reading. A phrase such as The idea drank tea is odd literally but may work in a poem or personification. Marking it ungrammatical would miss the difference between syntax and interpretation.

Meanings change through use. A word can broaden, narrow, acquire a technical sense or develop a new evaluative association. Polysemy can emerge from these changes. Learners should note the audience, genre and date of a usage rather than assume every dictionary sense is equally current in every community. In academic writing, define a term that has a specialised meaning before relying on it in an argument.

Worked contrasts

Metaphor	The proposal is a bridge between two positions.
Metonymy	The classroom applauded: the people in it.
Collocation	make a decision / heavy rain
Literal oddness	The idea drank tea can work as personification.

Watch the distinction
A figurative interpretation is not permission to infer anything at all. Ground your reading in textual details and the situation.

Check your understanding

34.1 Identify the conventional collocation: make/do a decision.

34.2 Is The classroom applauded necessarily about a building making a sound?

35 / Heads, dependents and constituents

Pre-intermediate to Advanced

Syntax examines how words combine into hierarchical structures. A phrase normally has a head that determines important properties of the phrase. In the very useful book, book is the head of a noun phrase; very useful modifies it, and the helps determine reference. In very useful, useful is the adjective head and very modifies its degree. Larger expressions contain smaller expressions rather than forming only a flat sequence.

A constituent is a unit in a structure. Replacement can provide evidence: the very useful book can be replaced by it in I bought it. Coordination and movement may supply other evidence. No single test works in every context: replacing a string can introduce a new structure, and movement can be constrained for reasons other than lack of constituency. Use converging evidence.

Complement and modifier are different dependency types. A complement is selected or licensed by a head in a relevant construction, such as the letter as the object of wrote. A modifier adds descriptive information, such as yesterday in wrote the letter yesterday. Optionality is helpful but not decisive: a selected complement can be omitted in a context, and a modifier may be necessary for a communicative purpose. Different theories also analyse determiner structure differently; this book uses a simple NP teaching model.

Worked contrasts

NP head	the useful book: book
Nested phrase	[NP the [AdjP very useful] book]
Replacement	I bought the useful book. / I bought it.
Dependency	wrote the letter: selected object; yesterday: time modifier.

Watch the distinction
A phrase need not contain several written words. A single noun or pronoun can form a phrase in many analyses.

Check your understanding

35.1 Identify the head of the old house near the park.

35.2 What does replacement by it suggest about that expression?

36 / Clause patterns, arguments and adjuncts

Elementary to Advanced

A clause normally organises a predication around a subject and a predicate. Basic English patterns include subject-verb, subject-verb-object, subject-verb-predicative complement and patterns with two complements. Maya slept has no direct object; Maya opened the door has one; Maya is tired has a predicative complement describing the subject. Surface position alone does not make every postverbal noun phrase an object.

Arguments are participants required or licensed by the predicate’s lexical construction. Adjuncts add circumstances such as time, location or manner. Compare She put the book on the desk with She read the book on the desk. Put in this sense normally requires a placement expression; with read, the location can be added or omitted. The same type of phrase can therefore have a different structural role with different verbs.

Valency concerns a predicate’s complement pattern. Give can license recipient and theme in Give Ben the book or a theme with a to-phrase in Give the book to Ben. Not every verb allows the same alternation: explain the problem to Ben is ordinary, while explain Ben the problem is not accepted in the intended standard-English pattern. Learn lexical construction restrictions instead of applying a universal double-object rule.

Worked contrasts

Intransitive	Maya slept.
Transitive	Maya opened the door.
Predicative complement	Maya is tired.
Two-complement construction	Maya gave Ben a book.

Watch the distinction
Being grammatically optional is not the same as being unimportant in a message. An adjunct may contain the answer the listener needs.

Check your understanding

36.1 Is tired an object in Maya is tired?

36.2 Why does put differ from read in its use of on the desk?

37 / Finite, nonfinite and embedded clauses

Intermediate to Advanced

A finite clause includes a finite verb and can often stand as a sentence, although a finite clause can also be subordinate. That Maya arrived early surprised us contains a finite subordinate clause functioning as subject. I think that Maya arrived early contains one as a complement. The word that can introduce a declarative content clause and does not have the same role in every occurrence.

Nonfinite clauses use forms such as to leave, leaving or written without independently expressing the same finite tense-and-agreement pattern. I want to leave embeds a nonfinite clause; Leaving early was sensible uses an -ing clause as subject. A nonfinite clause can have an explicit subject in some constructions: for Maya to leave would be surprising; I saw Maya leave. In other cases the subject is understood from the larger construction.

Embedding creates hierarchy and can occur recursively: I think [she knows [the class has ended]]. The embedded subject and verb belong to their own clause. Do not force every complex sentence into one subject and one verb. For clarity in writing, identify which proposition is the main assertion and which provides background, a reason, a reported belief or a qualification. Very deep embedding may be grammatical but difficult to process.

Worked contrasts

Finite subordinate	I know [that she arrived].
Nonfinite complement	I want [to leave].
Clause as subject	[Leaving early] was sensible.
Recursive embedding	I think [she knows [the class has ended]].

Watch the distinction
Finite does not mean independent. A finite clause can depend on another clause, and a nonfinite clause can still contain a rich internal structure.

Check your understanding

37.1 Is that she arrived finite in I know that she arrived?

37.2 Identify the subject of the main clause in Leaving early was sensible.

38 / Relative clauses and dependencies

Intermediate to Advanced

A relative clause helps characterise a nominal referent. In the student who called me, who is related to the student and functions as the relative-clause subject. In the book that I bought, that is associated with the object position of bought in a common pedagogical analysis. It is useful to ask which role is understood as missing inside the relative clause rather than simply memorise a relative word.

English often permits omission of an object relative marker in a restrictive clause: the book I bought. It does not permit comparable omission of a subject marker in the intended pattern: the student called me has a different structure from the student who called me. Whose marks a possessive relationship: the student whose laptop broke. Where can introduce a place-related relative such as the town where I grew up.

Supplementary relatives are often set off with commas and supply an additional assertion: Lea, who lives nearby, joined us. In the formal model here, that is not ordinarily used to introduce a supplementary relative. Relative and content clauses can look alike: the claim that he made modifies claim through a missing object; the claim that he left states the content of the claim. Examine the internal clause, not only the word that.

Worked contrasts

Subject relative	the student who called me
Object relative	the book that I bought / the book I bought
Possessive	the student whose laptop broke
Content versus relative	the claim that he left / the claim that he made

Watch the distinction
Do not add a second object pronoun in the target standard form: the book that I bought, not the book that I bought it.

Check your understanding

38.1 Can that be omitted in the book that I bought?

38.2 Explain the difference between the claim that he made and the claim that he left.

39 / Structural ambiguity and attachment

Upper-intermediate to Advanced

A sentence can have more than one structure even when each word has a familiar meaning. I saw the student with the telescope can mean I used a telescope to see the student, or I saw a student who had a telescope. In the first interpretation the prepositional phrase attaches to the seeing event; in the second it modifies the student noun phrase.

Attachment affects interpretation because a modifier is understood with the expression it is structurally linked to. Old teachers and students can describe both groups as old, or old teachers alongside students of unspecified age. Prosody, discourse and plausibility can favour one interpretation, but a plausible interpretation does not remove the alternative structure from the language.

Lexical ambiguity and structural ambiguity can interact, but they are different sources of uncertainty. The word bank has multiple senses; with the telescope has competing attachment sites. In professional or academic writing, make the intended relation explicit. Using a telescope, I saw the student resolves the instrument reading. I saw the student who was carrying a telescope resolves the possession reading. Editing ambiguity requires identifying the structural source rather than merely replacing a random word.

Worked contrasts

VP attachment	I used the telescope to see the student.
NP attachment	The student had the telescope.
Coordination ambiguity	old teachers and students
Repair	Using a telescope, I saw the student.

Watch the distinction
Context can select a reading, but writers should not rely on shared context that their actual audience may lack.

Check your understanding

39.1 Give two readings of I photographed the visitor with the camera.

39.2 Is bank ambiguity usually lexical or structural?

40 / Fronting, inversion and information structure

Upper-intermediate to Advanced

English word order is constrained, but several constructions reorganise information. A passive keeps an affected participant as subject; a cleft highlights a selected element: It was Maya who called. Fronting can make an object a topic: That book, I have already read. Such constructions are not arbitrary rearrangements. Their grammar and discourse effect must be learned together.

Questions typically place a finite auxiliary before the subject. Other constructions also use inversion. A fronted negative or restrictive expression can trigger auxiliary-subject inversion in formal usage: Never have I seen that before; Only then did I understand. The lexical verb after did is a base form. In conditional inversion, Had I known means If I had known, and Should you need help means If you should need help.

Information structure distinguishes familiar or given material from new, contrastive or focal material. This distinction does not map perfectly onto subject and object. A subject can be new, and a fronted phrase can be contrastive. Prosody and syntax jointly guide the interpretation. Choose an ordinary clause when it communicates clearly; use a marked construction when its emphasis or topic organisation serves a purpose rather than simply to sound advanced.

Worked contrasts

Cleft focus	It was Maya who called, not Ben.
Topic fronting	That book, I have already read.
Negative inversion	Never have I seen that before.
Conditional inversion	Had I known, I would have helped.

Watch the distinction
Do not copy inversion into embedded ordinary questions: I know where she lives uses subject-verb order. Marked constructions have specific licensing conditions.

Check your understanding

40.1 Rewrite Only then I understood with formal inversion.

40.2 Paraphrase Had I known, I would have helped.

41 / Context, deixis and common ground

Elementary to Advanced

Pragmatics examines how an utterance is interpreted and used in a situation. Context includes participants, time, location, preceding discourse, shared knowledge and the activity underway. The sentence I will bring it tomorrow cannot be fully interpreted without identifying the speaker, the intended object and the relevant day. A dictionary meaning alone does not provide those values.

Deictic expressions rely on the context of use. Person deixis includes I and you; spatial deixis includes here and there; temporal deixis includes now and tomorrow. Social deixis can concern how a form signals a relationship or status in a language. A quoted or reported utterance may shift the interpretation: a narrator’s tomorrow and the quoted speaker’s tomorrow need not identify the same calendar date.

Common ground is information treated as shared for the purposes of a conversation. It includes what speakers take for granted, not necessarily what is objectively true. A writer addressing unfamiliar readers should not assume that this, the project or the previous result has a clear referent. Supply enough context to identify it. Interpretation can be repaired when shared assumptions prove mistaken: By here, do you mean this room or this building?

Worked contrasts

Person	I changes reference with the speaker.
Time	tomorrow is relative to a relevant day.
Place	here can mean a room, building or city.
Repair	Which project are you referring to?

Watch the distinction
Context is not an excuse for ignoring literal wording. Meaning, structure and contextual assumptions constrain one another.

Check your understanding

41.1 What information is missing from I will send it tomorrow?

41.2 Why might here be unclear in a remote conversation?

42 / Speech acts and indirect requests

Pre-intermediate to Advanced

An utterance can perform an action as well as express content. Speakers assert, ask, promise, warn, apologise, invite and request. A speech-act analysis distinguishes what is said, the communicative act performed and its effects on a listener. Saying I will send the file can function as a prediction or a commitment, depending on the circumstances and the speaker’s intention.

Sentence form does not uniquely determine communicative function. Can you open the window? has the form of a question about ability, but commonly functions as a request. It is noisy in here can report a condition or indirectly ask people to lower their voices. Indirect interpretation requires enough contextual evidence; it should not be assumed for every remark.

Conditions for an act matter. An effective promise normally involves a future action under the speaker’s control and an appropriate commitment. A person cannot ordinarily promise a stranger’s action without the relevant authority. Institutional declarations such as pronouncing a result require recognised procedures and roles. For learners, the practical task is to choose a form suited to the relationship and to make the requested action clear enough that the hearer need not guess.

Worked contrasts

Assertion	The meeting starts at nine.
Promise	I will send the draft by nine.
Indirect request	Could you lower the volume?
Context-dependent hint	It is quite noisy in here.

Watch the distinction
An indirect request can be polite, but it can also be too vague or manipulative in a particular setting. Directness and respect are not opposites.

Check your understanding

42.1 What act does Could you send the file? commonly perform?

42.2 Give two uses of I will call tomorrow.

43 / Implicature and cancellable inference

Intermediate to Advanced

An implicature is communicated indirectly rather than being part of what the sentence explicitly asserts in the relevant reading. If Lea asks whether Ben will attend and Maya replies His train was cancelled, Maya may suggest that he will not attend. The inference depends on relevance and contextual assumptions; the words themselves do not logically guarantee nonattendance.

A conversational implicature can often be cancelled without contradiction: His train was cancelled, but he found another way and will attend. Scalar expressions provide another example. Some students passed often suggests not all passed, but Some students passed - in fact, all did can cancel that suggestion. Distinguish this defeasible inference from entailment. [R3]

When interpreting a response, ask what it asserts, what alternatives were relevant and which assumptions support the implied message. A reply such as I have an early class may decline a late-night invitation without using no. However, it could also invite a change of time. In practical communication, check important inferences: Do you mean you cannot come tonight? Do not treat an inference as a confirmed commitment until the speaker has made the intention sufficiently clear.

Worked contrasts

Explicit content	His train was cancelled.
Possible implicature	He probably will not attend.
Cancellation	But he found another way and will attend.
Scalar pattern	some often suggests not all, though the inference can be cancelled.

Watch the distinction
Cooperative reasoning is a model for interpreting conversation, not a promise that every speaker is truthful, equally informative or culturally identical.

Check your understanding

43.1 Does Some students passed logically entail that not all passed?

43.2 Cancel the likely implication of I have an early class in response to an invitation.

44 / Presupposition and backgrounded meaning

Upper-intermediate to Advanced

A presupposition is information presented as already taken for granted rather than as the main point being asserted. Lea stopped cycling commonly backgrounds that Lea used to cycle. The main assertion concerns stopping. Certain lexical items and constructions tend to trigger such background assumptions, including stop, again and some factive verbs such as know. [R4]

Presuppositions often survive under negation: Lea did not stop cycling can still take for granted that she cycled before. This persistence is a diagnostic, not a universal mechanical rule. Context, embedding and explicit correction can change what is assumed. Accommodation occurs when a hearer provisionally adds an assumption to make an utterance interpretable.

Compare three layers. Lea owns a poodle entails that she owns a dog. Lea stopped cycling presupposes an earlier cycling habit in the normal reading. Some students passed often implicates not all, but that inference can be cancelled. Distinguishing the layers helps you evaluate persuasive language. Has the team fixed its mistakes again? introduces assumptions about prior mistakes and repeated fixing. A respondent may need to challenge the framing rather than simply answer yes or no.

Worked contrasts

Trigger	Lea stopped cycling: earlier cycling is backgrounded.
Negation test	Lea did not stop cycling can preserve the prior-cycling assumption.
Again	He arrived late again suggests an earlier late arrival.
Challenge	What earlier mistakes are you referring to?

Watch the distinction
Presupposition is not synonymous with every assumption anyone makes. Examine how the expression and discourse jointly present information as given.

Check your understanding

44.1 What is normally presupposed by Ben stopped smoking?

44.2 Why might a yes/no response fail to address a loaded question?

45 / Politeness, stance and professional register

Pre-intermediate to Advanced

Politeness concerns how language manages relationships, expectations and social costs in a setting. No fixed sentence is maximally polite in every culture or situation. A clear instruction can be appropriate in an emergency; an elaborate indirect hint can be unhelpful when a colleague needs a specific deadline. Consider the relationship, the burden of the request and the activity rather than adding please mechanically.

Hedging calibrates a claim or request: may, appears to, in this sample, would you be willing to. A hedge can indicate limited evidence, reduce imposition or leave room for disagreement. Too much hedging can also obscure responsibility or weaken a clear finding. Compare The results prove the method works everywhere with In this sample, the method appears to improve recall. The second specifies the evidential reach.

Stance expresses a speaker’s attitude or degree of commitment. A professional disagreement can acknowledge a goal, state a concern and propose a concrete alternative: I understand the deadline matters. Releasing everything tomorrow would leave too little time for testing. Could we release the core pages first? This is a reusable structure, not a universal cultural formula. Adapt the register while preserving clear commitments and avoiding promises beyond your control.

Worked contrasts

Direct but considerate	Please send the file by 3 pm so I can finish the review.
Qualified claim	The finding may apply to similar groups.
Acknowledged disagreement	I see the benefit, but the cost needs review.
Concrete alternative	Could we test a smaller pilot first?

Watch the distinction
A hedge should reflect a genuine limitation or relational purpose, not merely make a claim sound sophisticated.

Check your understanding

45.1 Rewrite This proves the system always works as a cautious evidence-based claim.

45.2 Give a professional alternative to Your plan is stupid.

46 / Discourse, cohesion and conversational repair

Intermediate to Advanced

A discourse is connected language in use, not merely a list of independently grammatical sentences. Cohesion concerns explicit links such as pronouns, repeated lexical material and connectives. Coherence concerns whether the ideas form an interpretable whole. A text can be cohesive but incoherent: This happened; therefore, that happened does not establish a sensible causal relation unless the content supports it.

Connectives specify intended relations. However contrasts; therefore presents a consequence; for example introduces an illustration; meanwhile relates events in time. Choosing the wrong connective can misrepresent evidence even if every clause is grammatical. Pronouns must also point clearly to an intended antecedent. Maya emailed Lea after she arrived is unclear when both arrivals are possible; repeating the name may be better than avoiding repetition at all costs.

Conversation uses turn-taking, response expectations and repair. An invitation makes acceptance or refusal relevant; a question makes an answer relevant. Delayed or qualified responses can carry social meaning, but interpretations remain context-sensitive. Repair resolves a problem in hearing or understanding: Do you mean Tuesday the sixth? By bank, do you mean the financial institution? Effective communication includes asking for clarification and revising an utterance, not only producing fluent language without interruption.

Worked contrasts

Cohesion	Maya bought a book. She read it that evening.
Contrast	The method is fast; however, it is expensive.
Reference repair	Maya emailed Lea after Maya arrived.
Conversational repair	Do you mean this Tuesday or next Tuesday?

Watch the distinction
Fluency does not require pretending to understand. A precise clarification is often more competent than a confident but incorrect inference.

Check your understanding

46.1 Distinguish cohesion from coherence.

46.2 Repair the ambiguous pronoun in Maya called Lea after she arrived.

47 / One sentence through six lenses

All levels: guided analysis

Consider a message from a colleague: Could you send the revised draft by Friday? Analysing it through several lenses shows why accurate communication cannot be reduced to one grammar rule. The request has a conventional wording, a grammatical structure, an intended deadline and a social purpose. A learner may understand each word but still miss the commitment being requested.

Phonetics concerns the actual production and perception of sounds. Unstressed you and the may be reduced; prominence on Friday can make the deadline salient. Morphology identifies send as a base form after the modal could and revised as a participial form functioning within the noun phrase. Syntax places could before the subject you in the interrogative; the revised draft is the object and by Friday expresses a deadline.

Semantics provides a content involving sending a particular draft no later than a relevant Friday. The definite article suggests an identifiable draft, but the context must establish which version is revised. Pragmatics commonly interprets the question as a request rather than a test of physical ability. Discourse connects it to prior work and creates an expectation of a response. A responsible answer clarifies the date or version if needed and states whether the deadline is feasible.

Worked contrasts

Grammar	could + base send; interrogative inversion.
Syntax	you: subject; the revised draft: object.
Semantics	by Friday indicates a deadline rather than necessarily on Friday.
Pragmatics	A request that needs acceptance, refusal or clarification.

Watch the distinction
Analysis does not have to be performed consciously during every conversation. Practise slowly so useful distinctions become easier to notice in real time.

Check your understanding

47.1 Does by Friday require sending exactly on Friday?

47.2 Write a helpful response if the date is unclear.

48 / A diagnostic workshop and study plan

Starter to Advanced

Use an evidence-based notebook. For each difficulty, record the original expression, the intended meaning, the setting and a revised version. Then label the layer most involved. I have met her yesterday is mainly a tense-and-time problem in the standard model. Failing to hear the reduced form of can is mainly a listening and sound-pattern problem. Interpreting a polite request as a literal ability question is mainly pragmatic.

A layered study plan starts with one manageable target. At Starter, focus on sound contrasts, simple noun phrases and be. At Elementary, connect routine and ongoing meanings with their constructions. At Intermediate, expand clauses, complementation, aspect and discourse links. At advanced levels, examine scope, qualification, information structure, register and the distinction between an asserted claim and an inferred message.

For each target, move from recognition to production. Read an example and explain its meaning; listen and identify the important forms; produce two contrasts; use one in a short exchange or paragraph; review with feedback. Maintain an error log, but include successful uses so the log does not become a catalogue of failure. Accurate technical labels are helpful only if they improve interpretation, intelligibility or communication. This handbook supports analysis and practice rather than offering an automatic diagnosis or a certification of proficiency.

Worked contrasts

Grammar diagnosis	I have met her yesterday => I met her yesterday.
Sound diagnosis	Listen for strong and weak forms of can.
Meaning diagnosis	Distinguish not all from none.
Pragmatic diagnosis	Check whether an indirect reply accepts, refuses or requests a change.

Watch the distinction
A single example rarely diagnoses an overall level. Use repeated performance across tasks and, when possible, teacher feedback.

Check your understanding

48.1 Create a recognition-to-production routine for articles.

48.2 Which layer most directly concerns the distinction between not all and none?

Answer key / 1 of 12

Alternative wording is acceptable when it preserves the relevant distinction.

01 / Language as a system

1.1 Phonetics concerns its physical articulation; phonology may also matter if a sound contrast is involved.

1.2 A temperature report and, in an appropriate setting, a request to close a window or turn on heating.

02 / Description, variation and register

2.1 Accent concerns pronunciation patterns; register concerns language choices suited to a situation.

2.2 One possible answer: Could you send me the file by 3 pm, please?

03 / Evidence, units and analytical tests

3.1 Is agrees with the singular head list in standard English.

3.2 Rarity can reflect subject matter, context, style or processing difficulty rather than an impossible structure.

04 / Morphemes and word formation

4.1 teach + -er + -s: verb root, agent noun derivation and plural inflection.

4.2 No. Smaller has comparative inflection; writer has a derivational suffix forming a person noun.

Extend the task: make two fresh examples showing the same contrast. If both seem equally possible, supply a context and explain the reading rather than memorising a label alone.

Answer key / 2 of 12

Alternative wording is acceptable when it preserves the relevant distinction.

05 / Word classes and grammatical functions

5.1 It is a noun phrase functioning as a direct object.

5.2 Very is an adverb modifying the adverb carefully.

06 / Nouns, number and countability

6.1 I need some information, or I need a piece of information.

6.2 A chicken can be an animal; chicken can refer to meat as a substance.

07 / Articles, reference and determination

7.1 An hour; a university. The choices depend on the initial spoken sound.

7.2 The first generalises about books; the second refers to books identifiable in the context.

08 / Pronouns, case and reference

8.1 He gave the book to me.

8.2 It is a dummy or expletive subject here, not a pronoun for an ordinary object.

Extend the task: make two fresh examples showing the same contrast. If both seem equally possible, supply a context and explain the reading rather than memorising a label alone.

Answer key / 3 of 12

Alternative wording is acceptable when it preserves the relevant distinction.

09 / Adjectives, adverbs and comparison

9.1 She speaks English fluently.

9.2 This task is easier.

10 / Verb forms, finiteness and auxiliaries

10.1 Did he go home?

10.2 Have is finite; been and waiting are nonfinite forms in the sequence.

11 / Tense, time and aspect

11.1 Leaves is a present-tense form with future reference.

11.2 The first can present a completed past event; the second presents reading as ongoing at the time of the call.

12 / Present simple and progressive

12.1 Walk is the ordinary choice for a routine.

12.2 Have expresses an activity in having lunch but possession in have a bicycle; the constructions have different meanings.

Extend the task: make two fresh examples showing the same contrast. If both seem equally possible, supply a context and explain the reading rather than memorising a label alone.

Answer key / 4 of 12

Alternative wording is acceptable when it preserves the relevant distinction.

13 / Past narration and the perfect

13.1 I met her yesterday.

13.2 The bus left first; the speaker reached the stop later.

14 / Future reference and modality

14.1 Must not prohibits the action; do not have to removes a requirement.

14.2 No. It presents leaving as a possibility, not as an established fact.

15 / Negation, questions and agreement

15.1 Do you know where the station is?

15.2 Who called Ben?

16 / Verb complementation and nonfinite clauses

16.1 I enjoy reading.

16.2 Omar is understood as the subject of leave.

Extend the task: make two fresh examples showing the same contrast. If both seem equally possible, supply a context and explain the reading rather than memorising a label alone.

Answer key / 5 of 12

Alternative wording is acceptable when it preserves the relevant distinction.

17 / Passive voice and information flow

17.1 The room has been cleaned.

17.2 To identify a responsible or otherwise relevant agent rather than leave the doer unspecified.

18 / Conditionals, remoteness and reporting

18.1 Would have: If I had known, I would have told you.

18.2 He asked me where I lived. Retaining live can be possible if the current residence is deliberately emphasised.

19 / Prepositions, particles and lexical patterns

19.1 Turn it off.

19.2 In: interested in linguistics.

20 / Coordination, subordination and punctuation

20.1 One answer: It rained, so we stayed home. A full stop or semicolon is also possible.

20.2 No. The restrictive relative identifies the subset of students who arrived early.

Extend the task: make two fresh examples showing the same contrast. If both seem equally possible, supply a context and explain the reading rather than memorising a label alone.

Answer key / 6 of 12

Alternative wording is acceptable when it preserves the relevant distinction.

21 / Speech, spelling and IPA notation

21.1 The palatal approximant at the start of yes.

21.2 Slashes indicate a phonemic representation; brackets indicate a phonetic realisation, potentially more detailed.

22 / Articulation: place, manner and voicing

22.1 A voiceless labiodental fricative.

22.2 In a nasal, airflow can pass through the nose while there is an oral closure; an oral stop blocks oral airflow before release.

23 / English consonant contrasts

23.1 Chip begins with /tʃ/.

23.2 A dictionary may use a conventional broad phonemic symbol; a detailed transcription describes a particular realisation.

24 / Vowels and diphthongs

24.1 No. Vowel quality as well as duration-related cues matters.

24.2 Its vowel quality changes along a trajectory within the syllable.

Extend the task: make two fresh examples showing the same contrast. If both seem equally possible, supply a context and explain the reading rather than memorising a label alone.

Answer key / 7 of 12

Alternative wording is acceptable when it preserves the relevant distinction.

25 / Phonemes, allophones and minimal pairs

25.1 No. They differ in several segments.

25.2 Their difference is largely predictable from context and does not ordinarily distinguish those English words by itself.

26 / Syllables, stress and schwa

26.1 Onset /s/, nucleus /ɪ/, coda /t/.

26.2 An unstressed form may be reduced; contrastive or emphatic CAN favours a strong form.

27 / Connected speech and grammatical endings

27.1 /t/, because the preceding /ʃ/ is voiceless and is not /t/.

27.2 Watches, because the stem ends in a sibilant; books normally adds /s/ without a new syllable.

28 / Intonation, prominence and accent choice

28.1 A contrast with another colour, if the context makes that alternative relevant.

28.2 No. Rising pitch also occurs in other discourse functions and is interpreted in context.

Extend the task: make two fresh examples showing the same contrast. If both seem equally possible, supply a context and explain the reading rather than memorising a label alone.

Answer key / 8 of 12

Alternative wording is acceptable when it preserves the relevant distinction.

29 / Lexical meaning, sense and reference

29.1 Yes. They can share a referent while conveying different descriptive content.

29.2 No. Dog can denote a category; a phrase and context can identify a particular animal.

30 / Meaning relations and lexical ambiguity

30.1 Part-of: meronymy.

30.2 Near a financial institution or beside a riverbank, depending on context.

31 / Composition, entailment and contradiction

31.1 Yes, under the ordinary category relation and the same interpretation of owns.

31.2 No. The animal could be of another kind.

32 / Quantifiers, negation and scope

32.1 No. Not every denies that all passed; it is compatible with some passing.

32.2 There is a particular book that every student read.

Extend the task: make two fresh examples showing the same contrast. If both seem equally possible, supply a context and explain the reading rather than memorising a label alone.

Answer key / 9 of 12

Alternative wording is acceptable when it preserves the relevant distinction.

33 / Events, states and participant roles

33.1 No. The progressive does not assert completion.

33.2 Experiencer in a common semantic-role analysis.

34 / Figurative meaning, collocation and semantic change

34.1 Make a decision.

34.2 No. It commonly refers metonymically to the people in the classroom.

35 / Heads, dependents and constituents

35.1 House is the head in the simple NP model.

35.2 It provides evidence that the expression forms a noun-phrase constituent in that use.

36 / Clause patterns, arguments and adjuncts

36.1 No. It is an adjectival predicative complement describing Maya.

36.2 Put in the placement sense normally selects a location complement; read does not require that location.

Extend the task: make two fresh examples showing the same contrast. If both seem equally possible, supply a context and explain the reading rather than memorising a label alone.

Answer key / 10 of 12

Alternative wording is acceptable when it preserves the relevant distinction.

37 / Finite, nonfinite and embedded clauses

37.1 Yes. Arrived is a finite past form in the subordinate clause.

37.2 The -ing clause Leaving early functions as the main-clause subject.

38 / Relative clauses and dependencies

38.1 Yes, in this restrictive object-relative pattern.

38.2 The first has a relative clause with claim linked to the missing object of made; the second is a content clause describing the claim.

39 / Structural ambiguity and attachment

39.1 The camera was used for photographing; or the visitor was carrying or associated with the camera.

39.2 The financial-institution/river-edge contrast is lexical ambiguity.

40 / Fronting, inversion and information structure

40.1 Only then did I understand.

40.2 If I had known, I would have helped.

Extend the task: make two fresh examples showing the same contrast. If both seem equally possible, supply a context and explain the reading rather than memorising a label alone.

Answer key / 11 of 12

Alternative wording is acceptable when it preserves the relevant distinction.

41 / Context, deixis and common ground

41.1 The identity of I, the referent of it and the relevant date for tomorrow, among other details.

41.2 The participants may be in different locations or may intend different spatial scales.

42 / Speech acts and indirect requests

42.1 A request to send the file, rather than merely an inquiry about ability.

42.2 A prediction about a future action or a commitment/promise, depending on context.

43 / Implicature and cancellable inference

43.1 No. Not all is a common conversational implicature, not the ordinary existential entailment.

43.2 One answer: I have an early class, but I can still come for an hour.

44 / Presupposition and backgrounded meaning

44.1 That Ben previously smoked, in the ordinary reading.

44.2 The question may background an unaccepted assumption; the respondent may need to challenge that assumption explicitly.

Extend the task: make two fresh examples showing the same contrast. If both seem equally possible, supply a context and explain the reading rather than memorising a label alone.

Answer key / 12 of 12

Alternative wording is acceptable when it preserves the relevant distinction.

45 / Politeness, stance and professional register

45.1 One answer: These results suggest the system can work under the tested conditions.

45.2 One answer: I am concerned about the cost and timing. Could we consider a smaller pilot?

46 / Discourse, cohesion and conversational repair

46.1 Cohesion consists of overt linguistic links; coherence concerns an interpretable relationship among ideas in context.

46.2 State the intended name: Maya called Lea after Maya arrived, or after Lea arrived.

47 / One sentence through six lenses

47.1 No. It normally sets the latest acceptable point in the relevant context. Earlier sending can satisfy it.

47.2 One answer: Do you mean this Friday, 9 October? I can send the revised draft by 2 pm that day.

48 / A diagnostic workshop and study plan

48.1 One possible routine: identify a/an/the in a text, explain reference, listen for forms, write new-versus-identifiable noun phrases, then review a short paragraph.

48.2 Semantics, particularly quantifier and negation scope, with context sometimes relevant to interpretation.

Extend the task: make two fresh examples showing the same contrast. If both seem equally possible, supply a context and explain the reading rather than memorising a label alone.

Technical terms / 1 of 2

Return to the units for examples, qualifications and practice.

Accent	A pattern of pronunciation associated with speakers or a variety.
Adjunct	A modifier adding circumstances or description to a construction.
Allomorph	An alternative form of a morpheme.
Allophone	A contextual realisation of a phoneme in an analysis.
Argument	A participant or complement licensed by a predicate.
Aspect	A grammatical viewpoint on a situation’s temporal organisation.
Clause	A structure expressing a predication, often with subject and predicate.
Common ground	Information treated as shared for discourse purposes.
Complement	A dependent licensed by a head in a particular construction.
Constituent	A unit in a hierarchical syntactic structure.
Countability	A noun use’s compatibility with counting and determination.
Deixis	Context-dependent identification through expressions such as I or here.
Derivation	Word formation creating a new lexeme.
Entailment	A content relationship in which truth of one guarantees another.
Finiteness	Clause-level status associated with tense, modals and agreement patterns.
Head	The central element determining key properties of a phrase.
Implicature	An indirectly communicated inference beyond the explicit assertion.

Technical terms / 2 of 2

Return to the units for examples, qualifications and practice.

Inflection	A grammatical form variation of a lexeme.
Lexeme	An abstract lexical item represented by its related word forms.
Modality	Expression of possibility, necessity, ability, permission or obligation.
Morpheme	A minimal unit associated with meaning or grammatical function.
Phoneme	A contrastive sound category within a language variety.
Phonetics	Study of the physical production, transmission and perception of speech.
Phonology	Study of sound contrasts and patterns within a language system.
Pragmatics	Study of interpretation and communicative action in context.
Presupposition	Information presented as background or taken for granted.
Reference	Identification of an entity or entities by an expression in use.
Register	Language choices associated with an activity, relationship or setting.
Scope	The domain over which an operator is interpreted.
Semantics	Study of conventional meaning and its systematic composition.
Syntax	Study of hierarchical combination into phrases and clauses.
Telicity	A predicate’s association with an inherent endpoint.
Tense	A grammatical category relating a situation to a reference time.
Valency	A predicate’s licensed complement pattern.

Reference notes and further reading

Verified links for notation and extended study.

R1 / International Phonetic Association

Interactive IPA Chart

Use the official sound demonstrations and descriptions. The handbook uses original example tables, not a reproduced IPA chart.

R2 / Cambridge Dictionary

English Grammar Today: Tenses and time

A reference for the distinction between tense forms and time reference. Construction labels used in language teaching remain useful.

R3 / Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy

Implicature

Advanced background on indirectly communicated meaning and its relation to what is said.

R4 / Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy

Presupposition (Fall 2024 edition)

A detailed treatment of presupposition triggers, diagnostics and competing analyses.

R5 / eCampusOntario

Essentials of Linguistics, 2nd edition

An open university-level resource for further study of language systems. Notation and theoretical approaches may differ from this handbook.

Reference links checked on 4 October 2026. The original instructional explanations and exercises are not quotations or reproductions of these resources. Further reading is optional; follow the topic sequence to use the book independently.